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Context

Ottorino Respighi (1879-1936) was an Italian composer best known for his three tone poems describing different aspects of Rome, all written during or after a six-year period living in the city. The most popular of the three is *The Pines of Rome* (1924), evoking, across four movements, the images of I) children playing at the Villa Borghese gardens, II) the deep catacombs beneath the city, III) a night scene with a nightingale (including calling for the novel use of a phonograph recording of the bird to be played alongside the instruments), and IV) the height of ancient Roman power. This short story is heavily inspired by the progression of the musical suite, and follows, with liberties taken, a similar path / plot (though “plot” is a very loose word to use in this case, as neither piece, mine or Respighi’s, has any clear form of cause and effect through the sections).

The Pines of Rome

Rome is one of the most beautiful places in the world—or so I hear from others, I’ve never actually been. From all the pictures of the area though, I have little reason to doubt them. Both the city and the countryside around it exhibit a quality not seen here in the States. Rome was the seat of power of the Western world for longer than any nation today has existed, full stop. Even when the Roman Empire fell, the location continued to hold influence through the Holy See. There’s such a palpable history there, strong enough to be transmitted through photographs and felt on the other side. Everything takes on a holy form of consecration.

The fountains spewing water in the squares, for example, even though they were built just 200 years ago, absorb that majesty and rise above most all others in the world. The festivals, performed as they would be in any city, develop a much deeper weight when on top of the same roads that Nero, Caesar, and Augustus world. The first metropolis, having fallen from its throne but retaining the regalia.

Not even the trees are immune. Being such an old city, trees are ingrained right into the structure of the city itself. Let me paint you a picture: looking to the left, you see a small thicket of pines just beyond the current street. Shrieks carry over the light breeze as a group of young children dart out from behind the trees. They're obviously at play, seeing the wide smiles of joy across their faces. Such pure joy you haven't felt in so many years. Why shouldn't you relax for a second? A mid-autumn sun shines comfortably in a sky near devoid of cloud. When the children return back into the wood, into the unknown, you spare a glance to take in the day. Right next to you, in the road, going to their destinations, you see residents from all walks of life. A maid moves to the next assignment of the day. A carpenter carries a slab of wood to whatever project he's working on. A suited businessman reads his watch and quickens his pace. A young boy cries out the new story detailed by some newspaper. You quickly consider getting a copy—you had no time to read this morning—but at the sight of his youthful face, your mind returns to the children of the pines, and your gaze follows. Though now unseen behind the trees, their continued laughter remains audible. You start to make your way over to them, to get a better look at their genuine joy. Maybe it'll help you.

The crowd streams around you with a few grumbles of annoyance as you begin to slowly walk, but you pay them no mind. They don't have what you are after, and so you are all but blind to them. Closer inspection reveals the individual faces of the children. A young boy of three or four, beaming as he chases the others on the dirt and leaf paths, clothes dirtied from the forest. A girl of four runs, arms out, away from the

boy. A toddler of maybe two and no discernible gender waddles in leaps and jumps, enjoying their own company, safely out of the way of the runners. You watch as the boy scampers out of reach up the branches of a pine, and the girl calls out No fair! with hands on hips, clearly a learned gesture.

You unconsciously smile at their play; your eyes cloud over for what felt like just a second, but when they open a nanny is leading the children away, her words spoken too low to make out. Had she been there the entire time? You move to sit on the grass, to enjoy the last bits of brightness before you should return home. It's Sunday, and you still have a few things to get ready for the week ahead. But oh, a minute wouldn't hurt anyone. Glancing down reveals a great blanket of pine needles hidden below the hand-tall grass. The trees are behind you, towering above. From the ground here, they seem to stretch higher into the sky than anything else. Glancing over your shoulder shows that only maybe twenty feet into the woods do the branches and trunks completely block your sight. A gust of wind way off the ground blows through the trees, not felt by you but seen by the swaying tops and quiet *shhhh* of the needles moving off each other. Something in that yawning darkness calls to you. There's a certain draw to the mystery of an unknown wood, and you carefully rise and move toward the treeline. The swish of the grass underfoot turns to the crunch of dry needles—pine trees turn the soil acidic, so no grass can grow immediately around them.

You enter the forest. Immediately, the din of the street behind you falls away, leaving only silence occasionally broken by noise from some distant critter. The sun above is still company, but scarcely visible owing to the thick layer of needles between you and it. You feel yourself changing with each step: your breaths deepening, clawing for the moist natural air; your shoulders relax the grasp of life loosens; your posture straightens and the slightest of smiles takes root. But right when you reach that natural state, you feel another force appear, this one dragging you deeper into the wood. Maybe it was an innate desire to just be done with

it all, all the needs and responsibilities that we call life. Your mind has never been clearer, but you don't consider the meaning of that. You didn't want to. A small shake of the head and a quickening of step follow. You just need to go, to move, to keep moving. The trunks come at your face faster and faster, but it is no large feat to avoid them. Faster and faster still—you only now notice that you are speeding up. As you reach a full run, the jubilant shrieks of the children behind reenter your mind. The sound, even the memories of them, are more powerful here, in contrast to the cramped and oppressive darkness around. You hold onto that emotion, reaching into the past for all that had been lost or sealed away. Memories start flowing back into your mind—you remember how well it started—you remember how it all fell apart before your eyes—you remember *him*, how he helped you through it all—you remember his beautiful face, whose smile could clear any clear any cloud and brighten any day—you remember all your time spent together, how he would—

Catacombs. The thoughts shatter as you nearly run into the rough, weathered stone entrance. You've read enough to know that Rome has catacombs, but had yet to actually see them. The ancient tunnels exist exclusively outside city limits—you suddenly question the time, but all forms of timekeep are absent your person and the coverage above is much too thin to think this far into the forest to gauge the position of the sun. It is just as quiet inside the catacombs than out, but much more disconcerting. You can feel a discordant rumble, just barely able to be felt. You're squarely in the dominion of the past and of the dead now. The centuries-old bricks stretch down a gently-curving hallway. Each step you take echoes into the unknown ahead. Luckily, these graveyards haven't been used since the First Roman Republic, and with no plagues or other mass death events, no need for skulls and femurs stacked atop one another to conserve space. Instead, each body is buried separately. The first tunnels were built only a few decades into Anno Domini, by and for the first Christians. Some of the walls will be adorned with paintings of important religious figures—in fact, these tombs are an

invaluable source for Roman history, though unfortunately not the ones you are in now. Maybe these bodies were not rich enough, or maybe it was still too early for that. You're no expert, just an amateur historian with a soft spot for fallen empires. But you know that these bodies would have been the richest of the Christians in their time. Now, they're merely bones. The tunnel branches. You've no clue of which way to go, or even if there is a right choice. You go left, further into the catacombs. Coffins line either side of the walkway, countless of them going all the way down with corpses in each one.

You look at one. The solid stone lid is much too heavy to lift, despite your efforts, but that doesn't stop you from imagining. Maybe this one was a wine merchant, wealthy beyond desire, but failing to find any real meaning in life. He turned to the image of Jesus in an attempt to assuage that pain, and went to his death mostly successful. This next one? The wife of a low-ranking senator, buried with him following his conversion despite her indifference to the religion. It's a fun game, wondering about all the lives that could have come before. A short, unconscious glance down the row reminds you of the enormity of it all. The catacombs stretch for over a hundred and fifty thousand meters across a few dozen tunnels, each housing a few thousand bodies waiting for that afterlife that never came. Each person having held all their own hopes, dreams, regrets, secret loves, ancient memories, and private monologues, all inexorably lost with death. And this group only representing a small, disproportionate sample of Rome. The size is enough to stagger anyone, and you take a moment on the container to your side. This one could have been a blacksmith, working all his life and dying naturally, the only children left being his crafts, now also lost. You push the image from your head as the memory of the running children once again resurfaces. As with the forest, the thought easily shines brilliantly in the darkness. You fully turn to your thoughts as you continue walking. That was all anyone wants, wasn't it? To be out in the light, to not be alone on this pitiful world, to make your time here

worth something. Ideas so simple to say, so easy to put down onto paper and to communicate, yet nigh impossible to ever come close to achieving. Those children were on the right track, perhaps as close as they'll ever get to chasing that dream of bright, unadulterated joy. But those experiences will slip from their young minds faster than anything. No one ever truly succeeds. Some come close, some approximate, some claim to, but there's never true success in this quest. Why should we even try? There's always that metaphorical nanny to the side, out of view but in reach, ready to pull us back to reality and all the entitled chains. Everyone ends up the same, and the bodies passing by serve their grim purpose to this fact. Over millennia, differing in country, religion, beliefs, in everything, we still share the final destination. The last note, the enduring resolution. So then, why try? Best make use of the time, all that we're given, and only given conditionally at that. That we have the chance to live is incredible in and of itself, to waste it is tragedy.

Stumbling over the uneven stones underfoot, your train of thought concludes and your attention returns to the graves around you. This part of the catacombs feels... different. You are more in tune with the section here. When you first entered the tunnels, there had been a few low-lying rumbles, present enough to be noticed but soft enough to ultimately ignore. However, those had not been sourced from the entrance; it is here obvious that what you had felt were merely echoes of what is contained deeper within. You feel the stony and sweeping tones from the walls around you, those which can only come from the dead, left for so many years to come together in unison. It's enough to make your very bones rattle alongside those in the tombs beside you. You hardly have to try to stay with these ethereal movements—and they are definitely otherworldly, nothing like this could possibly come from humans, you think. These bodies, you continue, they've been here... so long. They've seen the change of the seasons, the endless circle of life, the rise and fall of empires more than anyone alive could even begin to comprehend. And in all that time, they all came together

to form this melody. Some others might try to call it music, but here in the moment, you know them to be wrong. Whatever this is, there are no vibrations, no sounds, no harmonies, merely a deep impression of such. Could anyone write it out onto paper? They could try, but it would undoubtedly be so far less than even an approximation of the true experience. Everything is perfectly still, perfectly silent, yet these time-worn walls around you enforce the dark loneliness. The tones reach a climax, the lows resolving their sweeping movements with backing and support for the mids; there are only a few high tones, the majority having died out long ago. The sequence completes and fades back into the nothing it came from.

You continue moving through the catacombs. Silly games of imagining what could have been no longer cloud your thoughts. You pass by each coffin, reverent and unknowing to each of their precise pasts, but understanding them collectively. You finally emerge from the tunnel onto a clearing on a hill, having walked far enough that Rome is safely behind and below you. It is also now nighttime, moon and stars gleaming in the sky above you. You take in the landscape. A forest surrounds you—still of pines—sparse enough to see quite a distance through, but far from a barren hillside. The branches down the plains all merge into one layer towards the horizon. It's a bit cooler here, the constant breeze running through your hair contributing. The nearby trees sway together in that breeze, uniform in motion but slightly offset in time. Further out, the patterns emerge into ginormous waves, moving across the forest with the wind. The near-full moon above casts the scene into a dim, grayscale tone. Not a dark tone, most certainly not, just the low light of a calm night.

For the first time, you feel truly alone. Just as with the woods before, you relax in the dark. There are no people around, dead or alive, and the city is behind you. No one ventures out this far but to move between towns—but there is nothing this way. Completely alone in the peaceful night. You begin to walk through the

trees. Each are the same—imposing cones of barely-visible green against the black sky mottled with clouds—yet each is also unique with clear character. Some have more branches just above the ground, others’ trunks are absent until several feet up. A handful feature giant knots from past struggles. There are almost as many dead, rotting stumps as there are live pines. And the forest just keeps going, on and on for eternity. Obviously, it’s not truly forever, but even in broad daylight, it would likely reach far beyond eyesight. And among it all, you, alone.

The only sound had been the irregular hissing of the wind in the trees, but as you walk the calls of a nightingale’s night song waft over the hills. It is a lone voice in the forest. The bird calls out again and again. Some of its calls are short and angular screeches that, repeated, cut through the noise of the wind, but most are long warbles that slowly drift along as they fade. All are beautiful. There is no evident overarching melody or tune, but the sounds merge with their echoes merge and form an incredible sort of harmony. Looking up in the trees, you are unable to see the bird among the branches, but that doesn’t stop you from listening more. You sit down in the grass. It is about a foot or two tall here, but that doesn’t matter. Sound carries perfectly fine over these large fields. You just sit and take in the song.

The night slowly progresses as you sit. The stars above turn over hours, the wind changes direction and strength and handful of times, the nightingale intermittently sends out more calls before stopping for the upcoming day. The first hints of sunlight are smudging the eastern sky, enough to illuminate much more the of the plains and its trees. You can make out the faraway details of the forest: the pines do indeed stretch for further than the eye can see, disappearing with the immense rolling hills. The general theme of the forest is the same, but different patches show small differences, whether in color or thickness of brush, off into the distance. The wind still sends waves of movement across the landscape; with the coming day and warming,

the upper wind and its effects are noticeably stronger than the night. You gaze once again at the now-fewer stars overhead, the moon having fallen below the horizon. As you sleepily blink at them, they merely twinkle back. Stars above and pines around, it's truly a sight to behold. You just stay right as you have been, laying in the grass. The end to the nightingale's song has left you feeling lonely. You had initially welcomed the unbroken lonesomeness, but after hours of hearing the bird's calls, you now just feel... isolated. You immediately recognize how silly such a feeling is—Rome, the sprawling metropolis, is right over the hill only a little ways to your side. But no, you stand and walk away from the city, farther into the trees.

Each of the individual pines is still just as full of personality as before, if not more so given the additional details now visible in the light. The moss growing on the bark and the veins traveling up and down the trunk—xylem, was it? Your biology knowledge from years before has all but left you—give each tree an entirely new depth. They weren't just shapes and silhouettes in the dark, but growing organisms preparing for the new day. Likewise, the forest as a whole was more than a canvas for time and nature to decorate. The trees all come together and make one large living body, with, for this little bit, you inside it.

You rise from the grass and continue your journey. After only maybe twenty minutes, you find yourself in front of a cobblestone road that looks about as old as time. The head-sized stones were clearly in a grid originally, but the countless number of footsteps has broken, turned askew, and rounded out the edges to them. The road stretches straight in either direction, melding into the dim dawn light. Pines line both sides of the path, having shielded it from your view on the hill. You suddenly remember—this road is the Via Appia, built around 300 BC and having served as a critical transport lane for the Roman Republic and Empire. It all but fell out of use in the Dark Ages and now remains as a piece of history. You rest for a minute, back to a tree, to watch the sunrise. The forest blocks your view of the horizon, so you must instead look to the final

disappearing stars and the lightening sky above. Nature truly is beautiful. You watch as the trees ahead begin to take on the red-orange tints that the east is strongly exhibiting. The stars fade away.

A rumble shakes you from your stupor. This one is a real movement, unlike before, and it is almost like a sound of the lowest pitches, just barely able to be heard but also easily felt. It is not so strong that the leaves nearby are affected, it almost seems that you are the only thing around to register the shaking. The very ground shakes—something very large is nearby. Two glances down the way reveal nothing to see, though sight is of course far from trustworthy now. Actually, it's not merely nearby, just also approaching: the vibrations are definitely strengthening. As they grow stronger, you can make out their texture much better—it is far from a continuous sensation, instead a rhythmic pulsing. Boom... boom... boom... a sudden shock, a fade away, before another shock; boom... boom... boom... all beats equally spaced, even. The eeriest of feelings takes hold as you spare a single thought as to what the source could possibly be. It's certainly nothing you've ever felt before, like the footsteps of a giant. The pulses grow stronger still, the texture better made out, and you realize that they are coming from your right, undoubtedly down the Via. You squint your eyes into the distance as you watch... something appear over the slight downwards curve of the stones. A single dot against the darkness. It suddenly flashes in a gleam of the sun—there must be fewer trees down there—and you conclude that the object is metal.

The image clears up into that of a man—an overly decorated man. He is wearing a Roman military uniform, though fancier than any you've ever had the privilege of seeing. The sheet metal is so cleaned and polished as to practically be a mirror, each section perfectly interlocking with all the others around it. There are small pieces of leather attaching all the armor pieces together, but also many larger pieces going up around the shoulders, the waist and everywhere else that are clearly ornamental. All are dyed a vivid red. Several white

ropes join the ornamental leather straps to give a shockingly clean color palette, between the red, white, and polished gray. An extravagant hat featuring a plume of beautiful scarlet feathers juts above his head alongside a perfect little spear for show. This man is obviously a senator, or similar high rank in the Roman military. If he sees you, he pays you less than no mind, his face showing such incredibly elation that your spirits rise at the sight.

The shaking is quite annoying in strength, and looking beyond that one man, you immediately find the source. An entire legion of thousands of footsoldiers marches perfectly in step, each in the same attire. Military uniform and armor, no doubt, but much less ornamental and much more practical than the leader of the legion—these men do the fighting. The metal pieces are considerably thicker and not perfectly hammered—merely shaped well enough to provide ample mobility when needed. Their helmets are utilitarian metal surfaces. The gray and red accents are nonetheless just as recognizable among the mass as it is on the frontman. The soldiers generally show faces of elation as they walk past. This legion must be returning from a victory, returning back to the Roman capital. Triumphantly.

The lines of legionnaires are now passing right by you now—also ignoring you—and you can further marvel at the uniformity of their movement. All steps are exactly the same, in both motion and time. There is a gap in the grid a ways forward, and a few different men fill the gap. These are completely different in look, and the only ones to differ—they wear of course the same red-white color scheme, but feature no armor, instead wearing loose, almost ceremonial robes. They carry long, thin circular tubes of metal that flair out on one end, which you assume to be an archaic form of horn. The loop forms almost a full circle, perhaps two and a half feet in diameter, looped around and under the shoulder. They seem quite unwieldy to use in any

situation, let alone endlessly marching with them. On the battlefield, these men would likely make calls to direct the footsoldiers, but now they walk in line with everyone else.

The horns are all raised to mouth in unison, and a triumphant fanfare explodes out of them. The volume surprises you, as the instruments seem much too thin to make such a blast. The tune is forceful and clear to the point—we have fought, and we are victorious, it says. It is simpler of a melody than you are accustomed to in the modern day, but in fairness such signals must be in order to be recognized from hundreds of meters away over fighting. As the fanfare nears its end, time seems to slow down for you. The horns climb to their highest, final note, and with it the soldiers unleash a roar of victory just as the sun first illuminates them as it finally lifts over the treeline. And there you see it, the true majesty of the Roman Empire. This is not just some dead society to read about and reference, it is the greatest power of all time, commanding most all of Europe for untold centuries. Not just one of several, not the first among equals, but *the* central influence and leader. It took power, devised novel systems to manage governance and enforce civility, and laid the foundation for practically every facet of the model world, from art to law to the natural sciences. No, they did more than just the foundations; their work rose far above the ground, with cities of a million people and the wherewithal to support them. Even the synonymous term ‘bread and circuses’ is originally from the Roman Empire. And people sure did remember them—so much today harkens back to the Romans. Their language, one of the centerpieces of culture, outlives the empire by a millennia; even if no longer used commonly, it has founded itself as a root language of half of those spoken in Europe today.. The names of Roman figures like Nero and Caesar are as household names as modern countries’ rulers. In world events and history even, Rome has permanently served as the foil for new powers. Since 476, many (if not all) a fledgling empire have used the Roman name and ideals as a distorted form of ethos—most notably the Holy

Roman Empire, but also the United States to a lesser extent—hoping to inspire support for themselves by recalling the past. But, the HRE, along with all others, is in no way, shape, or form truly Roman. Nothing is. Nothing, no creation, power, or anything else, will ever approach the pure splendor of the peak Rome. And you can see that in the men in front of you. One could say, Oh, they're merely ordinary men, they don't make an eternal empire, and they would have a point, if a severely misguided point. The men were ordinary—most men are—but all that surrounded them in their lives was far from. The soldiers carry spears and wear armor of such a high quality then only possible in such a long-lived advanced society. Each piece is hand-crafted with such an expert eye that every set is perfectly uniform. The decoration of the uniform—because a merely functional military is not enough for this empire—are likewise constant across the ranks of soldiers, all straps and ropes pristinely dyed and laid in place, bar those that had been disturbed in the preceding fight. And then beyond the material boasts, all the structure that must exist to create such perfection. A robust power structure and set of laws enables the capital to raise the men, material, skill, and capital required for the greatest force in human history. On a larger scale, the Senate makes deliberated choices on behalf of the populace while the consuls and magistrates serve as the head of state and government. It's a beautiful republican system, so no wonder it survived for centuries. One of the few that truly balances ardent military expansion with stable home rule. Then, a key factor to the previous, is the incredible psychology of the Roman people. Nationalism isn't the right term—or at least, it's a vastly different form of nationalism than seen today. Every Roman truly believes in the system that they live in, and is willing to support it. These soldiers even more so, putting their lives on the line. All that Rome founded in the generations prior only enabled them to forge an even stronger empire in the current one. And every people bound in the same goal, to further their resident state. Did the citizens know that they were living in a peak of human civilization?

Almost certainly not, but they did know their fortune compared to nearby kingdoms. Roman citizenship was a personal pride above all else for so many, and outsiders would travel untold distances just to have a chance of being recruited into a legion to hopefully gain citizenship upon honorable discharge. Many of the men marching in front of you now are likely on that path. Is it crude to withhold the benefits of membership from so many, and perhaps also at times hurt their growth as an empire? Potentially, but it also ensured that the armies were at all times manned, and that the soldiers were truly committed to service. And that policy—only feasible during their time, what with all the immigration laws now—is such genius as to inspire awe in anyone who truly sees the vision. A pathway that supports all sectors of the empire at once—military during service and domestic support afterwards—is just completely absent from the present. And that loss of novelty and spark is what sets the Roman Empire above all others.

The final rank of soldiers walks past you, and as they walk into the distance over the hill towards the capital, emitting another triumphant yell, your vision fades. For a moment, everything is peaceful. There is no sound, no light, no movement, nay even a stray thought. Perfect relaxation. Is this the silence that the rest is of? That wouldn't be so bad.

You jolt awake and sit up from the grass around the tree. For a minute, you stay perfectly still bar for repeated blinking as you collect your thoughts from whatever sequence you just experienced. You look up at the sun—shit, it's nearly noon, and it's Monday. You're completely late for work. You stand and begin walking back down the ancient Via Appia, back to Rome.